Prepare to Keep Track of Your Wife's Care Before You Need To

Four prompts to write down what an ordinary week looks like now, figure out who could realistically notice changes, list what you'd need to agree with a future care team, and leave the clinical parts blank on purpose.

Where you are

Your wife is well, or well enough that nothing has to be decided. You've started thinking about a day when other people are involved in her care, and about how you'd know whether that care was going the way it should. You don't have a provider, and you don't need one yet.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have a plain description of her ordinary week today, a realistic list of who could keep an eye on things, and the questions you'd ask any future care team about sharing information and responding to a concern. The clinical thresholds stay blank, on purpose.

A one-page Starting Point sheet: What an ordinary week looks like now, Who could keep an eye on things and what they'd see, Questions for a future care team, What we won't decide ourselves, and When we'll look at this again.

Before you start

- A few notes about her ordinary week: sleep, appetite, getting around, what she does with her time.
- The names of people who see her regularly.
- Any thoughts about what kind of care you might one day consider. None of this needs to be finished.

PROMPT 1

Write down this year's normal

WHY THIS MATTERS

A year from now, someone may ask, is this new? You'll want to answer from notes, not memory. What's normal for your wife today is the most useful thing you can record, and it's the one thing only you can.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your observations about an ordinary week: sleep, appetite, walking, mood, how she spends her time, what she enjoys.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My wife is well and I'm writing down what an ordinary week looks like for her now, so we have something to compare against later. Here are my notes:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Organize them under: SLEEP, EATING AND DRINKING, GETTING AROUND, MOOD AND ENERGY, HOW SHE SPENDS HER TIME, and PEOPLE SHE SEES. Beside each item, mark whether I SAW IT, SHE TOLD ME, or I'M GUESSING. Keep my wording. Do not tell me what is normal or abnormal for someone her age, do not add warning signs, numbers, or things to watch out for, and do not describe these notes as a baseline for anything medical. If a section is thin, say so and suggest what I might simply notice next week.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A description of her week that she'd recognize, with your guesses clearly marked.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Date it, and plan to redo it in a year or after any big change.

PROMPT 2

Find out who could realistically notice

WHY THIS MATTERS

A tracker with no one to fill it in is a good intention. Before deciding what to watch, work out who is actually around, how often, and whether they'd be willing to write anything down.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The people who see your wife regularly: family, friends, neighbors, a cleaner, her hairdresser.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are the people who see my wife regularly, roughly how often, and what they tend to notice about her:
>
> [PASTE YOUR LIST]
>
> Make a table: WHO, HOW OFTEN THEY SEE HER, WHAT THEY COULD REALISTICALLY NOTICE, WOULD THEY BE WILLING TO MENTION IT, and WHO THEY'D TELL. Where I haven't said, write UNKNOWN. Then tell me which parts of her week, by time of day and day of week, nobody on the list sees. Finally, list the questions I'd need to ask these people before counting on them, such as

> whether they'd be comfortable telling me if something seemed different. Don't assign anyone a job; I'll ask them myself.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The hours of the week when no one is around, and the people you've been counting on without asking.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Have one conversation with the person who sees her most, and ask if they'd tell you.

PROMPT 3

List what you'd need to agree with a future care team

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families assume a provider will share notes, call when something's off, and know who to call. Some do, some don't, and none of it is automatic. Knowing the questions now means you ask them before signing, not after.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your thoughts about the kind of care you might consider, even if vague.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> We don't have a care provider for my wife yet, but we may one day. I want a list of questions to ask any future care team about how we would stay informed. Here is what I'm thinking about:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Group the questions under three headings: WHAT INFORMATION WE'D WANT, for example about daily care, changes in her routine, or anything they'd observe; HOW WE'D GET IT, such as records we could see, regular calls, or a named contact; and WHO WE'D CALL, separating a routine concern from an urgent one, in office hours and at night. Add one question about who sets and confirms any medical warning signs, since that isn't something we'll decide ourselves. Write questions only; don't answer them or describe what a good provider does.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions you'd never have thought to ask until something went wrong.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Keep the list with your care file. It's for the first meeting with any provider, whenever that is.

PROMPT 4

Write the Starting Point sheet

WHY THIS MATTERS

What you've made isn't a monitoring plan, and it shouldn't pretend to be. It's a starting point: today's normal, the people around her, the questions for later, and a clear statement of what you're leaving to professionals.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what I've prepared about keeping track of my wife's care in the future:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page sheet titled OUR STARTING POINT with five headings: WHAT AN ORDINARY WEEK LOOKS LIKE NOW; WHO COULD KEEP AN EYE ON THINGS AND WHAT THEY'D SEE; QUESTIONS FOR A FUTURE CARE TEAM; WHAT WE WON'T DECIDE OURSELVES; and WHEN WE'LL LOOK AT THIS AGAIN. Under the fourth heading, list clinical warning signs, response instructions, and when monitoring should begin as items for a clinician and care team, with no content from you. Under the last, put today's date and a blank for the next review. Do not add any thresholds, warning signs, or care recommendations.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A sheet where the fourth section is a list of questions and nothing else.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

File it with her other care papers and tell one other person it exists.

Record today properly

What you've written down about your wife's ordinary week is a snapshot. The care interview turns a snapshot into a Family Care Profile that covers her whole situation, which is what any future monitoring would be measured against.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›